

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman reflects on the morning of the 10th of Av—when mourning practices still continue—and connects it to Moshe Rabbeinu’s longing to enter Eretz Yisrael in Parashat Va’etchanan. He develops the Avnei Nezer’s reading that Hashem’s response “רַב לָךְ” is not merely a refusal, but a recognition of Moshe’s spiritual greatness: Moshe can “fulfill” the mitzvah through elevated desire and thought. Rabbi Shulman applies this to Tisha B’Av: even when we cannot bring korbanot or rebuild the Beit HaMikdash in action, we can attain a real spiritual “מַעֲלָה עָלֵינוּ הַכְּתוּב” through yearning, learning, and intentional kavannah.

I. Setting: the 10th of Av and continued aveilut

- Rabbi Shulman opens by noting that the Beit HaMikdash continued burning through the 10th of Av.
 - Therefore, certain mourning practices (not eating meat or drinking wine) continue until midday.
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II. Moshe’s tefillah to enter Eretz Yisrael—and Hashem’s response (0:31)

A. Moshe’s repeated request

- In the beginning of Parashat Va’etchanan, Moshe Rabbeinu begs Hashem to allow him to enter Eretz Yisrael.

B. Hashem says “no,” but tells Moshe to go up and see

- Rabbi Shulman quotes Hashem’s response:
 - **וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֵלַי רַב לָךְ אֶל-תּוֹסֵף דַּבֵּר אֵלַי עוֹד בְּדַבָּר הַזֶּה:**
(And Hashem said to me: It is much for you; do not continue to speak to Me further about this matter.)
 - **עֲלֵה רֹאשׁ הַפֶּסֶקָה וְשֵׂא עֵינֶיךָ יָמָּה וְצָפוֹנָה וְתִמְנָנָה וּמִזְרָחָה וּרְאֵה בְּעֵינֶיךָ**
(Ascend to the top of the cliff and lift your eyes westward, northward, southward, and eastward, and see with your eyes.)
- Moshe will not cross the Jordan, but he is instructed to view the land.

C. The Gemara's surprising claim: Moshe was “answered”

- Rabbi Shulman cites Berachot 32b: **שִׁנְעָה מֹשֶׁה בְּתַפְלָתוֹ**—Moshe's tefillah was answered, because Hashem showed him Eretz Yisrael.
 - Question raised (Avnei Nezer): how is that considered an “answer” if Moshe asked to enter the land, and was denied?
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III. Avnei Nezer: “מַעֲלָה עָלָיו הַכְּתוּב כְּאִלּוּ עָשָׂה” as spiritual elevation (2:32)

A. The principle: planned mitzvah + prevented by ones = credited as done

- Rabbi Shulman cites Berachot 6a:
 - If a person intended to do a mitzvah but was prevented by circumstances beyond control, the Torah credits it as if the mitzvah was performed: **מַעֲלָה עָלָיו הַכְּתוּב כְּאִלּוּ עָשָׂה**.

B. Precision in language: “מַעֲלָה עָלָיו” is not just “as if”

- Rabbi Shulman, following the Avnei Nezer, emphasizes the literal sense of **מַעֲלָה עָלָיו**:
 - not merely a metaphorical “as if,”
 - but an actual aliyah—a raising of the person to a higher spiritual standing.

C. The deeper idea: thought vs. physical blockage

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - In the physical world, the mitzvah may remain undone.
 - But if a person can “live” in the realm of thought—intent, desire, and inner reality—then on that elevated level, the mitzvah is genuinely present.
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IV. Re-reading “רַב לָךְ”: Moshe's greatness enables a different kind of fulfillment (4:30)

A. “רַב לָךְ” as affirmation, not only refusal

- Rabbi Shulman interprets Hashem's words **רַב לָךְ** as: you have a spiritual greatness—rav lecha—that makes another mode of fulfillment possible.

B. Why this works for Moshe more than for “regular people”

- For most people, not doing a mitzvah physically is experienced as a major loss.
- But Moshe’s level allows **מַעֲלָה עָלָיו הַכְּתוּב** to function in a truer, deeper way.

C. The directive to “go up and look” becomes avodah

- Hashem’s instruction is re-framed:
 - Go up, look at the land, study it, and yearn for it.
 - By thinking about what he would do there, Moshe attains an elevated “as if” accomplishment.
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V. Application to Tisha B’Av: yearning, learning, and korbanot in place of action (6:00)

A. The Tisha B’Av longing for the Beit HaMikdash

- Rabbi Shulman shifts from Moshe’s yearning for Eretz Yisrael to our yearning for the Beit HaMikdash.

B. “מַעֲלָה עָלָיו” through korbanot recitation and desire

- When we say sections about korbanot, Rabbi Shulman urges:
 - we should **yearn** to offer them.
 - Since we are prevented from doing so physically (beyond our control), this can become a genuine **מַעֲלָה עָלָיו**.

C. Practical pathway: learning about the Mikdash

- Rabbi Shulman lists learning goals that cultivate this elevation:
 - studying the building and structure of the Beit HaMikdash,
 - learning the avodah and conduct in the Mikdash,
 - saying and learning **פְּסוּמֵי הַקְּטָרֹת**, and related topics.

D. The hoped-for result

- Through this, we become more spiritual, “נשמה’דיקע” people, worthy of:
 - being credited with mitzvot we cannot currently do,
 - and ultimately, **בנין בית המקדש במהרה בימינו**, returning to actual performance **בפועל** ובמעשה ממש.

VI. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman frames the 10th of Av as a day that still carries Tisha B'Av's yearning and restraint.
- Moshe's denied request to enter Eretz Yisrael is reinterpreted (Avnei Nezer) as an "answer" through **מַעֲלָה עָלָיו הַכְּתוּב**—a real spiritual elevation achieved via desire and thought.
- becomes a statement of Moshe's greatness: his longing and contemplation can "רב לך" constitute a form of fulfillment.
- Practically, Rabbi Shulman urges channeling Tisha B'Av yearning into learning and kavannah—especially around korbanot and the Beit HaMikdash—so that we merit rebuilding it soon and returning to concrete avodah.